

BLAST FROM THE PAST
Shattered window panes of the Punjab Police Intelligence HQ in Mohali; remnants of the RPG shell

KESHAV SINGH/GETTY IMAGES

The Long Shadow of Khalistan

THE ATTACK ON THE PUNJAB POLICE INTELLIGENCE HQ IS A REMINDER THAT THE KHALISTAN ISSUE IS STILL SIMMERING. THIS TIME THE SEPARATISTS ARE USING GANGSTERS TO DO THEIR DIRTY WORK

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

IT **WAS AROUND 7.45 PM** on the night of May 9 when the intelligence wing headquarters of Punjab Police in scenic Mohali was suddenly rocked by a mini blast and the sound of shattered window panes. The attack, using an RPG (rocket-propelled grenade), happened when most of the sleuths had left for the day, so there were no casualties. But it again raised a security agencies bogey—the long shadow of the Khalistan movement hasn't faded away as yet.

Soon after the attack, a voice note landed at Himachal Pradesh chief minister Jai Ram Thakur's office claiming to be from New York-based Gurpatwant Pannun, founder of the banned Khalistani outfit Sikhs for Justice. It claimed